constructing its second domestic aircraft carrier in 2018.[102] In comparison, India has one aircraft carrier in active service (INS Vikramaditya), one under construction and expected to enter service in 2019 (INS Vikrant), and one planned to enter service in 2025 (INS Vishal).[103] Furthermore, India is planning to build new nuclear attack submarines (SSN), and the Indian navy reportedly seeks to more than double its fleet to 200 operational warships by 2027.[104] In late 2018, Prime Minister Modi proudly announced that the INS Arihant, India's first indigenously built, nuclear-powered ballistic missile-carrying submarine (SSBN), had completed its first deterrent patrol armed with nuclear missiles.[105] By 2022, India aims to have a fleet of four SSBNs, which would give it at-sea deterrent capability off both coastlines.[106] Although India's commitment to the IOR is obvious, the country's expenditure on the navy is limited when compared to those of India's counterparts. According to Aman Thakker of CSIS, in 2017–2018, 15 percent of India's total military expenditure was allocated to the navy. Comparable figures for India's partners in the informal Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (the "Quad") – the United States, Australia, and Japan – were 30 percent, 25 percent, and 23 percent, respectively. At the same time, China is now believed to spend a larger part of its defence budget on the navy than does India.[107] India's 2020–21 defence budget confirms the impression of a limited navy expenditure, reducing the navy's share to 13 percent.[108]

As evidenced by the Quad, India is indeed increasing its co-operation with countries outside the IOR littoral. This engagement among India, the United States, Australia, and Japan seems echoed in France's 2018 call for a "Paris–New Delhi–Canberra" axis in the Indo-Pacific.[109] Individual agreements with France and the United States have secured further footholds in the IOR for India – access to ports at the bases on Diego Garcia (US) and Reunion Island (French).